

Philosophy of History

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Historiography

The major contribution of philosophy to the domain of history is the insistence of authentic methodology and synthesis in the writing or discussion of history. This rational approach to history gave birth to Historiography.

Historiography refers to the application of the principles of academic discipline to the study and writing of history. For a study to be seen as a discipline, there should be a methodology that entertains a critical and analytic study. In other words, historiography is the writing of history based on the critical examination of sources so as to achieve authenticity. When these sources are verified, then the important details are sieved from these verified sources and synthesised into historical narratives that can stand a verifiable test. It is the writing of history by making use of certifiable techniques of research.

Naturally, before the art of writing, humans passed information about the past to the next generation by the use of stories. The veracity of such stories was authenticated only by their continued repetition. When humans invented literary writing, such narratives were also put in print. However, with historiography, the veracity of historical accounts was no longer from repetition but by verifying facts.

In a loose sense, it refers to any historical work that deals with a particular subject matter. It describes the body of history written about a particular person, period or event. For instance, the historiography of the Nigerian Civil War describes every significant book written about that war.

Historiography as a discipline is recent. It was developed in the 18th century. Before the 18th century, History was just seen as any other human activity but not considered as part of regular education or object of academic study. Academic disciplines then were poetry, religion, philosophy and so on. It was only during the Age of Enlightenment that scholars like Voltaire, Hume, developed Historiography and thus gave History an academic form. By the 19th century, historical studies became professionalized at universities and considered as an academic discipline¹.

In the words of Voltaire, “One demands of modern historians more details, better ascertained facts, precise dates, more attention to customs, laws, commerce, finance, agriculture, population”². Voltaire’s aim is to depart from the theological and regal assumptions and focus on verifiable facts

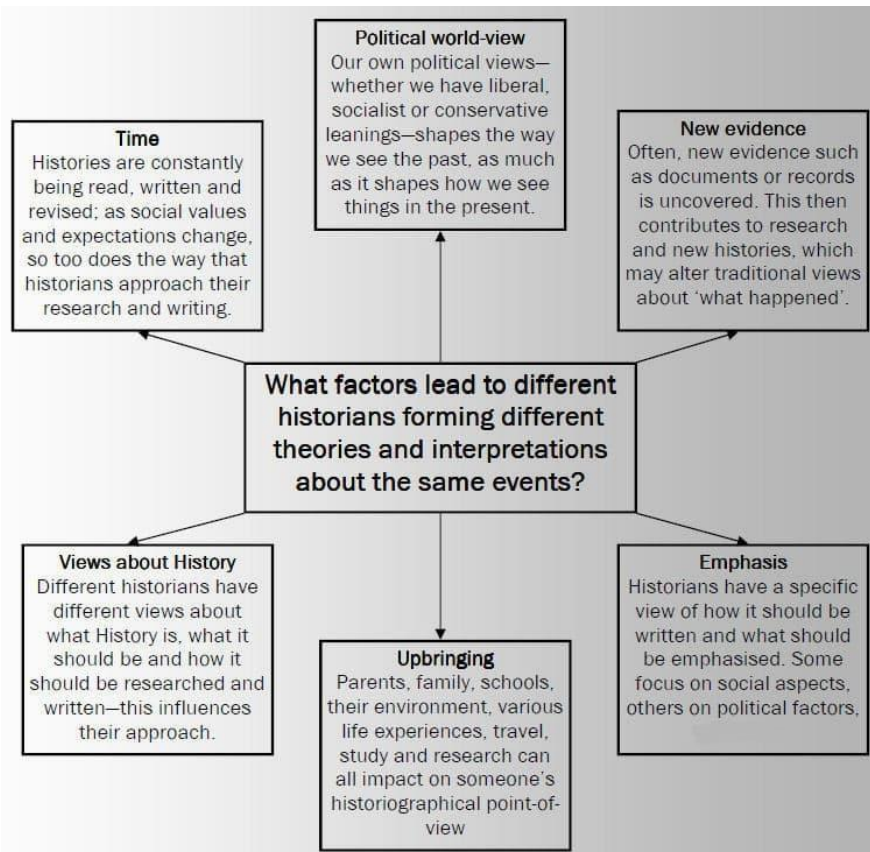
¹ Georg G. IGGER, *Historiography in the Twentieth Century: From Scientific Objectivity to the Postmodern Challenge*

² E. Sreedharan (2004). *A Textbook of Historiography: 500 BC to AD 2000*, (India: Orient Blackswan, 2004) p. 115

of history. He held that former historical accounts were falsified with superstitions and traditional tales to enhance the nobles and ecclesiastical authorities. To the contrary, he demanded that modern history has to be based on objectivity and anchored on verifiable and precise facts. Departing from the traditional way of recounting histories according to religious and imperial accomplishments, he focused rather on social history, accomplishments in the arts and sciences, economics, culture, and political history. He was the first scholar who made attempt to articulate the history of the world.

Historiographical Concerns

As historiography focuses on the method of writing history, it is concerned with not just the study of how history is written but also how our perception of it evolves or changes over time. In order to understand how and why historians' beliefs and interpretations differ, historiography takes into account the methods they employ.



From the above chart, it is clear that a lot of factors come into play in the evaluation and interpretation of the past. The way the past is interpreted can vary but yet the past itself never changes. Based on their individual approaches, values, and interests, contemporary historians investigate and analyze the past. They produce fresh hypotheses and findings that could alter our perception of the past. This process of transformation is recognized and studied in historiography.

Important facts to note about Historiography:

There are some basic things to note in the study of historiography.

First, we must acknowledge that history is never final. Even if the past never changes, our perceptions of it are constantly subject to debate, critique, and revision.

Secondly, historiography makes us understand that there is a difference between history and historical facts. History is the study and interpretation of historical events while historical facts refer to details that have been verified or proven true by evidence. Referring to historical facts, the role of the historian is to make sense of these facts through research and analysis. Historiography prompts the historian to examine and interpret evidence, form conclusions and articulate their findings in writing.